Original Article

Trust in the police in Latin America: A multilevel analysis of institutional and experiential models

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Abstract This paper explores two models of preference-formation of trust in the police in Latin America and the Caribbean: An *institutional* model that highlights the role of broad assessments of government performance and legitimacy and an *experiential* approach focussed on more narrow experiences of victimization and police contact. We examine these frameworks based on theory and analysis of administrative data and surveys from the Americas Barometer 2014 (N = 34,798 respondents T = 22 countries). Findings show that respondents with higher confidence in their government also indicate higher ratings of trust in the police. Similarly, trust is higher among individuals who had not experienced victimization or bribery or who anticipated faster police response times. At the country level, our results suggest that trust is negatively related to economic development but positively related to rule of law. We draw on these findings to outline an integrative model that combines both institutional and experiential perspectives.

Trust is a key component of conventional frameworks comparing political systems across domains of legitimacy or effectiveness (Herian and Neal, 2016; Llewellyn *et al.*, 2013; Putnam *et al.*, 1994). Trust is also part of more focussed approaches that examine the quality of criminal justice interventions beyond specific activities or outcomes such as arrests or service calls (Hohl *et al.*, 2010; Jackson and Gau, 2016; Tyler, 2011). Consistent with these two perspectives, some scholars relate individual-level perceptions of law enforcement to generalized assessments of institutional trust and quality of government and country-level measures of political stability and economic development (Bergman, 2002; Jang *et al.*, 2015) reflecting an *institutional* framework. Other strategies favour more specialized frames centred on crime experiences and police contact (Liebertz, 2020; Merry *et al.*, 2012), configuring an *experiential* model. These approaches prioritize individual-level correlates associated with victimization and police interaction (Jackson and Bradford, 2010; Manning, 2010) and country-level measures such as homicide rates and agencies staffing levels (Alda *et al.*, 2017; Cao *et al.*, 2012; Schaap, 2018).

Trust also helps to specify the nature of citizen-police relations: On the one hand varying institutional designs shape the legality, role, function, and mechanisms of delivery of policing services (Bowling *et al.*, 2019). In this way, trust in the police can signal appraisals of broader forms of state authority including its technical capacity, representativeness, or inclusivity (Bayley and

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Stenning, 2016). On the other hand, trust in law enforcement can evoke narratives of the self and others as shared histories of direct or indirect police contact or abuse (Bell, 2017). From a procedural justice perspective, trust in the police may be linked to localized perceptions of legitimacy framed by interactions with law enforcement (Bottoms and Tankebe, 2012; Tyler, 1990). Tyler for example, points out that individual perceptions centred on the exercise of formal authority shape a range of attitudinal and behavioural responses signalling compliance or cooperation (Nagin and Telep, 2017; Tyler, 2011). Beyond notions of police legitimacy tied centred on the perceived obligation to obey or ratings of neutrality of authority figures, trust in the police can also be seen as capturing a more normative component focussed on the 'perceived rapport between citizens and the state' (Rengifo *et al.*, 2019, p. 429). In addition, Cao (2022) argues that the levels of confidence in the police also shape police legitimacy based on the expectations of police action and performance to carry on their tasks. Following the author, procedural justice and confidence in the police are crucial concepts to understanding policing in democracy, particularly in stratified societies. Across this plurality of approaches, trust in law enforcement connects individual-level judgements and experiences to more macro-level forces associated with the perceived quality of government or the saliency of shared experiences of neglect and oppression (Legewie, 2016).

Although most research linking trust in the police with police-citizen encounters and forms of state authority has taken place in the global north, a growing body of literature has begun to interrogate general assumptions, mechanisms, and implications in the global south (Boateng and Buckner, 2019) and Latin America and the Caribbean (LAC) in particular (González, 2020; Hathazy, 2018; Cao and Zhao, 2005). This is a timely endeavour for the region because generally public safety policies developed over the past two decades have sought to reshape the relationship between the state and the citizenry under a Neoliberal framework (Iturralde, 2019; Sozzo, 2016). This has re-invigorated debates about police reform, oversight, and other ambitions of modernity tied to efficiency and rule of law (Bonner, 2019; Dias Felix and Hilgers, 2020; Frühling, 2009).

Despite efforts in conceptualization, a sharper, more substantive focus on the patterning of trust in the police in LAC is important for several reasons: Its homicide rate is almost three times higher than the worldwide average, concentrating 37% of all incidents recorded—a figure that underscores the exceptional demand for public safety and its centrality in policy debates. Beyond these general measures, it is critical to note that there are significant differences in levels of lethal violence within the region, from a low of 4.2 homicides per 100,000 in 2017 in Chile to a high of 61.7 homicides in El Salvador (UNODC, 2019). There is also considerable heterogeneity in crime prevention strategies implemented (Malone and Dammert, 2020; Ungar, 2010) and broader initiatives of police reform (Dammert, 2019; Mejía and García, 2013). This heterogeneity is seldom acknowledged, let alone explained in terms of theory or across levels of individual and contextual influences.

In this paper, we contribute to closing these gaps by exploring how two different perspectives can explain variations in levels of citizen trust in the police, and how these approaches may be integrated based on data and theory. To ground this assessment, we draw primarily on survey data from a cross-sectional regional survey conducted in 2014 (N = 34,798 respondents nested in T = 22 countries). As noted above, we conceptualize the *institutional* dimension of law enforcement perceptions as a reflective broad process of preference-formation anchored on assessments of democracy, government, and political orientation. We frame the *experiential* model as reflective of more narrowly defined experiences and perceptions related to crime, fear of crime, and policing. We operationalize each of these perspectives using both individual-level survey data as well as other country-level predictors, and assess the estimates derived from these multilevel models in terms of fit, variance components and covariates. We draw on these results to examine pathways for integration and implications for policy. This work is guided by three questions: 1. How do individual or contextual factors shape the perceptions of trust in the police in LAC?, 2. Which of the two models examined explains more fully the variation in the

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rating of trust in the police?, and 3. To what extent can these two models be integrated conceptually and empirically?

The conceptualization and analyses developed in this study contribute to the literature in three important ways: First, an explicit focus on perceptions of trust in the police provides a common ground to re-centre appraisals of law enforcement performance on democratic ideals of citizen experience and legitimacy (Mazerolle and Terrill, 2018; Meares, 2015; Tankebe, 2013). Second, our multilevel framework enables us to reframe debates about police perceptions as shaped by both individual and macro-level factors. For example, following the Institutional Anomie Theory, the primacy of economic institutions may strain forms and levels of other institutions in charge of enforcing social control (Messner and Rosenfeld, 2013; 2006). This dual focus is particularly salient for LAC and other regions of the Global South where heightened inequality and uneven provision of government – sponsored services may not only translate into more negative appraisals of police but also into a more central role for person-level experiences and attitudes (Johnson *et al.*, 2014; Malone and Dammert, 2020; Tyler, 2011). Concerns about the role of stratification and state abuse or neglect may apply to the Global North as well, and as such, it is critical for research and theory to map parallel patterns and mechanisms (Bell, 2017; Rengifo *et al.*, 2017). Finally, by exploring how to trust in the police may be shaped by both crimes as well as responses to crime we strengthen a local evidence-base that can inform future reforms in terms of benchmarks and targets, and the more critical need to consider the police as part of a broader system made of other government institutions and a plurality of other forces in civil society (González, 2020).

Institutional trust perspective

Trust is a multi-dimensional attitude that describes emerging properties of groups similarly to cohesion or solidarity, as well as characteristics of more individual-level exchanges and preferences (Coleman, 1994). According to Uslaner (2008), trust structures behavioural expectations rooted in values, life experiences, and cultural backgrounds. Hawdon (2008) extends this perspective to suggest that trust can also signal normative expectations about corporate actors. The notion of institutional trust integrates these expectations with others related to the quality of political regimes and governments (Citrin and Stoker 2018). For instance, Zmerli and Newton (2008) use data from the European Social Survey (N = 38,600) to show that levels of trust in national agencies are positively correlated with feelings of satisfaction with democracy.

Consistent with these perspectives, research on police performance and police-citizen relations has considered trust in the police as part of a broader set of indicators of police responsiveness and related assessments of civic engagement and integration. In a classic study, Albrecht and Green (1977) analyse survey data to show that favourable perceptions of law enforcement are clustered around broader forms of trust—e.g. they find that respondents with positive attitudes about the police also signal positive perceptions about the legal system. From a more comparative perspective, Stack and Cao (1998) draw on data from the World Values Survey to examine confidence in the police in a sample of individuals in industrialized countries. Their results show that political conservatism is associated with more positive perceptions of the police because this institution is seen as a reflection of order and the status quo. Similarly, Cao and colleagues (Cao *et al.*, 2015) analyse the same data to examine how perceived in-group trust (people with close stronger ties) and out-group (people not related and culturally less familiar with weaker ties), are mediated by the perception of democracy, explain the variation in the outcome of institutional in confidence in the police and courts via perceptions of democracy. The authors draw data also from the World Values Survey 2005–2006 from three different cultural contexts to perform a series of SEM models. Their results indicate highlight that higher levels of in-group trust and higher favourable perceptions of democracy are positively related explain to confidence in courts and the police. However, this does not apply to the out-group trust and the findings are not significant and negatively associated with the outcome. In contrast, this may be explained by the in-trust group and democracy producing more confidence in order institutions.

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Taken together these and other studies show that attitudinal assessments of police work are often associated with valuations of other institutions. Easton, for example, points to the relevance of political support for public authorities when explaining perceived outcomes and ratings of the performance of government and political actors (Easton, 1975). Political support is often linked to various types of socialization processes and experiences that can contribute to shaping trust and legitimacy in formal institutions. In LAC specifically, Cao and Zhao show that conservative political attitudes predict higher levels of trust in the police and suggest that this is part of a broader framing of institutional perceptions (Cao and Zhao, 2005).

Other studies have reconceptualized the notion of trust to frame the performance of criminal justice institutions in terms of legitimacy or satisfaction (Cao, 2015; Jackson, 2018a; Jackson *et al.*, 2013; Kochel *et al.*, 2013). Consistent with this approach, several authors in LAC have explored the relationship between perceptions of safety and the quality of national political systems (Blanco, 2013; Dammert, 2016; González, 2017). For example, Liebertz (2020) studies the effects of 'iron fist' policies centred on repressive tactics and heightened surveillance on citizen ratings of local institutions. Drawing on survey data from the Americas Barometer 2008, findings show repressive policies moderate negative perceptions of institutional trust in the judiciary and the police. Additionally, the author points out that politicians' 'tough on crime' narratives produce crime anxiety. This factor is more effective in aligning police perceptions than political affiliation (Liebertz, 2020). Moreover, results indicate that this pattern is more pronounced in the case of high-crime countries—a finding that underscores the importance of decomposing the variance of trust across levels of analysis.

Experiential trust perspective

The experiential trust perspective seeks to synthesize studies showing that perceptions of trust in law enforcement are shaped primarily by patterns of individual exposure to crime and police contact (Cao *et al.* 2012; Gau 2010; Kääriäinen and Sirén 2011; Rengifo and Slocum 2020). As noted by several studies, victimization is a critical covariate of public attitudes toward the police in the USA and Europe (Merry *et al.* 2012; Weitzer and Tuch 2005). As noted by Monica Bell, however, this process is not just the reflection of discrete interactions but also the effect of cumulative and collective experiences, particularly in social contexts marked by heightened tensions between the community and the police (Bell, 2017). For instance, Rengifo and colleagues (Rengifo *et al.*, 2019) show that a negative effect of cumulative contact on crime reporting intentions

In the global south, the context and correlates of police encounters have not received systematic attention, especially in quantitative studies. However, this is changing: For example, Sozzo and colleagues' (Sozzo *et al.*, 2020) analysis of a four-wave survey is set to patterns of contact between the police and citizens in Argentina. Findings from a series of logistic regression models show that levels of satisfaction reported by victims when reported crimes to the police have decreased over time due to more general negative perceptions that they have of law enforcement. Other research has found that fear of crime is negatively associated with trust in the police (Alda, Bennett and Morabito, 2017; Singer *et al.*, 2019). For instance, Alda and colleagues (Alda *et al.*, 2017) use structural equation modelling to show that high levels of victimization and fear of crime undermine trust in justice agencies, including the police, but this effect is observed in developing countries and not in more industrialized nations.

Direct police encounters may shape trust in law enforcement as well. In particular, studies have emphasized the role of procedural justice in the formation of more cooperative behavioural or attitudinal responses by individuals exposed to varying forms of police contact (Nix *et al.*, 2015; Tankebe, 2013; Tyler, 2011). Procedurally fair interactions can improve perceptions of the police during specific encounters as well as broader ratings of institutional performance. Other approaches follow a similar argument but focus on assessing negative police contacts in the preference-formation process by citizens. These experiences include, for example, incidents of use of force, bribery, and corruption, with studies showing for example that individuals who report direct and vicarious experiences also are associated with lower public perceptions about the police, specifically reducing levels of trustworthiness, perceived procedural justice and

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effectiveness (Jackson, 2018b; Tankebe, 2010). In a comparative study that follows a similar logic, Jang and colleagues (Jang *et al.*, 2015), analyse data from World Values Survey (N = 58,637; T = 49) and find that countries with higher rates of perceived corruption also have lower rates of confidence in the police. Like in the case of criminal victimization and strained forms of police contact, citizens may consider specific experiences marked by ineffective or abusive practices as proxies for overall assessments of institutional performance. For instance, Malone and Dammert (2020) based on data from the Americas Barometer shows that trust in the police across most countries in the region is driven by considerations of (lack of) effectiveness tied to victimization and police response time. Consistent with this perspective, other studies show that local police encounters often result in mistreatment, corruption, and excessive use of force, correlating these experiences with more negative views of the police (Cruz, 2015; Cruz *et al.*, 2017).

Indirect or vicarious experiences of police contact may also shape perception of police trust and legitimacy, particularly among individuals who have no direct contact with officers (Rosenbaum *et al.*, 2005). In these cases, the sharing experiences may favour negative encounters and reinforce broader collective frames that emphasize adversarial/oppositional attitudes or cynicism to law and law enforcement (Bell, 2017; Pryce and Grant, 2021; Weitzer and Tuch, 2005).

Contextual factors and trust in the police

The form of state authority, as well as relative levels of economic development and crime, not only capture variation in exposure to violence, opportunity structures, and resources for crime control, but can shape perceptions of trust in the police more directly. As shown by cross-sectional studies, for example, higher homicide rates are typically associated with lower levels of confidence in the police (Cao and Zhao, 2005; Kääriäinen, 2007).

Trust in the police may also be influenced by economic development. Positive expectations of economic performance and the expansion of markets may signal general prosperity and increasing institutional capabilities due to higher tax revenues and investment (Algan and Cahuc, 2013; Baliamoune-Lutz, 2011). However, criminological theories suggest that different mechanisms may be at play: For example, Institutional Anomie Theory points out that the primacy of economic institutions may strain forms and levels of other institutions in charge of enforcing social control, which includes conventional forms of policing under the aegis of the polity (Messner and Rosenfeld, 2013; 2006). According to Routine Activities theory, long periods of economic growth trigger structural changes that may lead to more suitable targets, although simultaneous increases in public or private spending can also result in more suitable guardians (Cohen and Felson, 1979).

In a recent contribution, Bergman (Bergman, 2018) argues that the economic growth experienced in LAC between mid-1990s and 2014 created new opportunities for crime. Criminal organizations took advantage of the illegal markets that paralleled the deregulation and internationalization of formal economies. The resulting increase in crime was amplified by criminal justice agencies that were already weak due to failed institutional designs, but that became more isolated and corrupt.

Another key contextual factor that may influence trust in the police is the rule of law. This notion illustrates the capacity of governments to implement, delivery and comply with legal rules and procedures associated with economic and political development (Heckman *et al.*, 2010; Lacey, 2019). Rule of law may be associated with trust in local institutions because a stronger sense of compliance and respect for norms and procedures may translate into higher perceptions of legitimacy and quality of representation (Doyle, 2011). In global south countries, a weaker compliance with the rule of law by citizens and state authorities has been found to be highly correlated with institutional distrust and public dissatisfaction with the government (Bergman, 2002; Davis, 2006; Malone, 2010; Smithey and Malone, 2014).

Whither theoretical integration?

We examine the institutional and experiential perspectives outlined above through the lens of

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a broader debate about pathways to theoretical integration. Whereas theoretical competition was common in the 1970s–1980s, more recent contributions have moved away from simply testing which approach could offer a better explanation of a phenomenon along dimensions such as variance explained or parsimony (Messner *et al.*, 1989) to more comprehensive perspectives exploring various strategies to integration. It suggests that theories can make different predictions about the same phenomenon in a process that may not be inherently contradictory (Bernard and Snipes, 1996).

There are three major types of theoretical integration: conceptual, propositional, and cross-level (Krohn and Eassey, 2015; Messner *et al.*, 1989). Conceptual integration synthesizes frameworks based on assumptions, principles, or other components. Propositional integration focuses on respecifying the causal order and logic of a given outcome. As part of propositional integration, a side-by-side strategy aligns different perspectives in a parallel approach meant to support more holistic models. In this study, we consider the institutional and experiential perspectives are providing seemingly different explanations of trust in the police. However, rather than pitching them against each other, we seek to explore in what ways their unique contributions may complement each other. Moreover, our formulation of each perspective already embeds a particular type of multilevel integration by which we explain trust as shaped by both respondent and contextual factors (Bernard and Snipes, 1996; Matsueda, 2017). In this manner, our interest in realigning multiple approaches across levels and substantive contributions extends long-standing efforts in the discipline to integrate theories of crime with a new focus on frameworks that describe and appraise the operation of criminal justice institutions in different contexts (Carrington *et al.*, 2016).

Current study

We examine two models of trust in the police in LAC countries that highlight institutional or experiential correlates based on seemingly different underlying processes: In the case of the institutional model, we take the literature to suggest that social control is a core mechanism linking individual perceptions of the police to broader ratings of state agencies. Specifically, we argue that general valuations of state capacity reflect subjective judgements about the ability of the polity to enforce social control through policy and ideology (Messner and Rosenfeld, 2013; 2006). This type of assessment may anchor ratings of specific institutions such as the police, especially in environments marked by state action that is disproportionately coercive or authoritative. These conditions are particularly salient in LAC countries but may be traced to specific contexts in the global north as well.

In the case of the experiential model, we argue that prior police contact or victimization may shape ratings of trust in the police via underlying assessments of police effectiveness or responsivity (Tankebe, 2013). Consistent with this hypothesized mechanism, the experiential perspective favours narrow, specialized appraisals of policy capacity and service-delivery that are not embedded into broader views of state capacity or ideology. Instead, these appraisals signal more of a routine activities framework by which the 'capacity' of guardians is assessed in specific settings (Cohen and Felson, 1979). Consistent with this perspective, individuals may also anchor trust in the police based on their own behaviours and ability to implement protective measures to reduce the likelihood of victimization (Rengifo and Bolton, 2012).

We use multilevel modelling to explore these approaches quantitatively across contextual characteristics and individual factors (Hox *et al.*, 2018). This approach is well suited to model variation between and within countries as ignoring this clustering leads to biased estimates (Rabe-Hesketh, 2012). As noted in the introduction, our analyses are guided by three research questions: 1. Is trust in the police shaped more by individual factors or contextual factors?, 2. Which of the two models mentioned above better explains this variation?, and 3. How may these approaches be reconfigured as an integrated side-by-side model?

Data and methods

The Americas Barometer is a regional data collection carried out by the Latin American Public Opinion Project. From 2004 to 2018, the survey

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was conducted every two years, resulting in seven independent waves of survey data across countries in North America and LAC. We draw on the 2014 dataset, which includes information from N = 34,798 respondents across T = 22 countries. Each country sample is nationally representative and was designed using stratified multistage clusters. Sample sizes ranged from 1,489 observations in Ecuador to 3,066 in Bolivia (LAPOP, 2014).[1]

The 2014 survey targeted one voting-age adult in randomly-selected households. Individuals who agreed to participate answered questions via face-to-face interviews. Their responses were recorded using an electronic device to enhance data quality. The common questionnaire focussed on opinions and experiences related to the quality of the local democracy and government, with more specific questions linked to crime and public safety (Blanco, 2013; Krause, 2014).[2]

The dependent variable used in all our models is trust in the national police, measured by a question asking respondents, *'To what extent do you trust the National Police?'*[3] Responses are classified using a 7-point scale ranging from 1 = Not at all to 7 = A lot (Mean = 3.74, SD = 1.91). This approach is consistent with other regional studies that rely on single survey items to measure citizen attitudes toward the police (Malone and Dammert, 2020) and with a broader set of studies that rely on multi-item scales centred on the notion of trust to examine perceptions of police legitimacy and effectiveness (Rengifo and Slocum, 2020; Tankebe, 2013).

Consistent with the institutional perspective, we include in the model trust in political actors and institutions related to trust in the judicial system, trust in the executive, trust in political parties, trust in local government, and trust in elections. Ratings of these institutions are measured with the same standardized question (*'To what extent do you trust…'*) and a range of answers (from 1 = Not at all to 7 = A lot). We average individual survey responses to create an Institutional Trust score, ranging from 1 to 7 points (M = 3.63, SD = 1.35)[4]. We also use five survey-based measures of satisfaction with government services and policies to assess the citizens' satisfaction with state-funded services. Specifically, we examine satisfaction with democracy (*'In general, would you say that you are very satisfied, satisfied, dissatisfied or very dissatisfied with the way democracy works'*), satisfaction with government programs including public works (*'Thinking about the city/area where you live, are you very satisfied, satisfied, dissatisfied or very dissatisfied with the condition of the streets, roads and highways'*), schools (*'…the quality of the public schools'*) and health care (*'…the quality of public medical and health services'*). The responses to each of these items were recorded consistently across questions (from 1 = Very dissatisfied to 4 = Very satisfied). We average these answers to

[1] The Americas Barometer uses a probabilistic design of voting-age adults in each country stratified by region and urban/rural areas that yields nationally representative samples (LAPOP, 2014). Also, in a series of preliminary analyses of the study sample we observed that the prevalence of missing data for both dependent and independent variables was generally low (<1%), with no significant variation across individual characteristics or countries. For these reasons, our study sample is based on the list-wise deletion of cases with partial information.

[2] We focus on the 2014 wave of the Americas Barometer because it was the most updated dataset publicly available at the time of writing. Like other waves of the survey, the 2014 wave included Canada and USA. However, these countries were excluded from analyses given our substantive focus on LAC countries.

[3] In LAC most police organizations are centralized agencies. As such, due to the centralized nature of most police organizations, the concept of 'national police' embedded in the police trust survey question is adequate. In LAC countries with federal systems the following adjustments were made to this question: Military police (Brazil), [unspecified] 'police in general' (Mexico and Argentina). In that sense, the question about trust in the police focuses on the attitudes about the police and law enforcement as a public-service function and as a social institution rather than the particularities of local police organizations operating within the country to explain the variation in trust ratings among them.

[4] We separate police trust from the institutional trust given differences in the scope of these appraisals (narrow versus broad) and forms of state authority (coercive versus non-coercive) (see Citrin and Stoker, 2018). Empirically, the correlation between these two variables is moderate (r = 0.52), which mitigates issues of collinearity (see Appendix 2).

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create a four-point Citizen satisfaction with government services score (M = 2.50, SD = 0.51)[5]. We expect these scales to be positively associated with variation in trust in the police because more positive assessments of specific public services and utilities may project across other areas of government.

As part of the institutional model, we include a political orientation variable measured as a ten points scale ranging from 1 = left/liberal to 10 = right/conservative ('*According to the meaning that the terms "left"/"liberal =1" and "right"/'conservative =10" have for you, and thinking of your own political leanings, where would you place yourself on this scale?"*)[6] (M = 5.4, SD = 2.7). We expect more politically conservative respondents would trust the police more given identification with the order, stability, and status quo.

Consistent with the experiential model, we examine the association between trust in the police and sector-level covariates focussed on crime and police-related attitudes and encounters. These covariates include prior victimization ('*Have you been a victim of any type of crime in the past 12 months?*', 1 = Yes, 0 = No) (M = .18; SD = .38) and police response time ('*How long do you think it would take the police to arrive at your house on a typical day around noon? (In a case of burglary)'* measured using a 6-point categorical scale ranging from 1 = less than 10 minutes to 6 = police would never arrive) (M = 3.25 and SD = 1.47). We also include an individual-level dummy regressor that captures police bribery or corruption ('*Has a police officer asked you for a bribe in the last 12 months*?', Yes = 1, No = 0) (M = 0.11 and SD = 0.32) and another fear of crime regressor ('*In order to protect yourself from crime, in the last 12 months, have you taken any measures such as avoiding walking through some areas in your neighborhood because they are dangerous*', Yes = 1, No = 0) (M = 0.42, SD = 0.49). We anticipate that these variables will be negatively related to trust in the police because victimization incidents affect the perceived effectiveness of the police to address crime and violence. Moreover, bribes undermine citizens' trust because officers become offenders, weakening their authority. Similarly, fear of crime could shape trust in the police because the lack of formal social control provided by law enforcement increases victimization risk.

Both sets of models of trust in the police include individual-level controls. These are respondents' sex (Male = 0, Female = 1) (M = 0.51, SD = 0.50), age in years ranging from 16 years old to 99 years old (variable computed 'In what year were you born?') (M = 40.6, SD = 15.92,) and family's economic situation measured using a dummy regressor (Not poor = 0, Poor = 1) (M = 0.53, SD = 0.50). Years of schooling is a continuous variable measuring individuals' educational attainment level ('How many years of schooling have you completed?', *None = 0 to University =18 or more)* (M = 9.41, SD = 4.36).

We also include a small set of country-level predictors limited by the sample size of countries in the survey (T = 22)[7]. In connection to the institutional model, we add the World Bank rule of law index (2019) defined as the aggregate perception of key informants regarding local compliance with statutes and contracts, property rights and sense of the integrity of the judiciary (M = 35.64, SD = 22.93). We expect that this indicator will be positively related to the outcome because it reflects the capacity of governments to enforce rules and make individuals and institutions accountable. The rule of law is an important concept in the global south given

[5] We use principal-components factor analysis (varimax rotation) to extract these underlying constructs from survey responses. The internal consistency of the Institutional Trust scale is high (α = 0.77) suggesting that this measure has adequate reliability. In the case of the scale measuring citizens' satisfaction with government score, we find slightly lower but still acceptable reliability (α = 0.63). For more details see Appendix 3.

[6] In the survey the scale was left = 1 right = 10 for the survey applied in 21 countries in our sample. In the case of Guyana, the category was Liberal = 1 – Conservative = 10. We merged both questions because the questionnaire uses the same scale (1–10) to avoid dropping the country from the analysis.

[7] We checked for potential multicollinearity issues by estimating Variance Inflation Factors (VIF) for all predictors (Hox *et al.*, 2018). According to test results, the VIF values for the three country-level regressors were below the recommended threshold of VIF = 10 (mean VIF 1.58). We obtained similar results for all level-1 variables (see Appendix 2).

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that it measures the relative centrality of the state in the organization of society—a function that may be compromised by uncertainty in legislation or partisan politics, external influences, or state-capture by private actors.

Consistent with the orientation of the experiential model we use 2014 homicide rates (logged) as contextual factors capturing patterns of overall exposure to violence.[8] This indicator is reasonably well recorded and systematically used for comparative analyses (M = 22.59, SD = 19.34, rates per 100,000 residents) (UNODC, 2019). We anticipate that homicide rates will be negatively related to trust in the police because higher levels of lethal violence shape perceptions of safety and police effectiveness.

Across the two models examined we also use the gross domestic product (GDP) per capita in 2014 U$ (M = 6,541, SD = 3,985) as proxy for economic development (ECLAC, n.d.). This factor may influence trust from an institutional perspective via the effects of relative prosperity on other forms of social and human capital (Algan and Cahuc, 2013). In addition, economic development may influence trust from an experiential perspective by altering resources to enforce social control (Messner and Rosenfeld, 2006; Bergman, 2018).

Our estimation first fits an ANOVA model that only controls for the clustering of survey responses across countries (Rabe-Hesketh, 2012). Next, we add predictors using a stepwise strategy guided by our choice of theoretical models given that we find significant variation at both individual and country levels. All level-1 predictors were group-mean centred (Hox *et al.*, 2018). For our mean analyses, we consider trust in the police to be a continuous level-1 variable, although in a series of supplementary models we check estimates derived from alternative specifications and other strategies to measure contextual effects and then we run each multilevel model for the three dimensions: institutional, experiential, and integrated.

The summary of these analyses proceeds as follows: first, we provide an overview of the variables employed in the model. Second, we combine level-1 and level-2 variables for each of the two models of trust in the police already defined. We examine each of these models separately, and then as a single, integrated model.

Results

Table 1 provides an overview of the distribution of the main dependent variable of the study and the full range of predictors and controls referenced above.[9] Across all respondents, levels of reported trust in the police were low to moderate (M = 3.739, SD = 1.901, in a scale of 1 to 7) although we find substantial variation across countries, from a low of 3.12 (Guyana) to a high of 4.95 (Chile) (see Fig. 1). Levels of institutional trust and satisfaction with gov. services follow a relatively similar distribution (M = 3.626, SD = 1.350, and M = 2.501, SD = 0.509, respectively). The political orientation measure reaches a middle-range value with significant dispersion across countries (M = 5.356, SD = 2.722). In connection to the experiential model, the dummy variable for victimization shows that on average for the overall sample, 18% of the individuals were victims of crime in the prior twelve months. Similarly, 11% of respondents reported having been asked for a bribe by a police officer in the same time frame. Fear of crime—measured by a dummy variable—shows that 42% of the people in the sample avoid walking in dangerous areas in their neighbourhoods. These statistics confirm that the region is marked by heightened levels of crime, insecurity, and low levels of institutional capacity and integrity. Yet, there are also within-region differences in measures of state institutions and public safety.

[8] We implemented a log-transformation to mitigate the impact of extreme values in estimation routines.

[9] Multilevel models based on survey data typically require weights at all levels of analysis to produce unbiased parameter estimates (Rabe-Hesketh, 2012). According to LAPOP (2019), their data collection relies on 'overall' weights defined by the probability of selection of an individual in a given cluster (country). The absence of country-level weights in the sample design could potentially produce a bias estimation in the models. For that reason, an ad-hoc country-level weight was created to reflect the probability of a cluster being selected and the subsequent probability of an individual being selected. This weight was calculated by taking a country's population relative to the proportion of its survey sample size.

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Table 1: Descriptive statistics

	N	Mean	SD	Min	Max	Models
Outcome						
Trust in National Police	34,798	3.739	1.909	1	7	
Individual-level regressors						
Institutional trust score	33,203	3.626	1.350	1	7	Institutional
Citizen satisfaction with gov. services score	30,324	2.501	0.509	1	4	
Political orientation scale	29,433	5.356	2.722	1	10	
Victim of crime in the last 12 months	34,872	0.180	0.384	0	1	Experiential
Police response time (Burglary)	33,764	3.245	1.472	1	6	
Police corruption or bribery	34,800	0.112	0.315	0	1	
Fear of crime	34,750	0.424	0.494	0	1	
Sex	34,979	0.513	0.500	0	1	All models
Family economic situation	34,060	0.527	0.499	0	1	
Age, years	34,912	40.598	15.922	16	99	
Schooling, years	34,864	9.414	4.357	0	18	
Country-level regressors						
Homicide rate per 100,000 population (2014)	22	22.591	19.340	3.400	66.900	Experiential
Ranking rule of law (2014)	22	35.642	22.935	0.481	87.981	Institutional
GDP per capita (2014)	22	6541.403	3985.282	735.674	14,530.950	All models

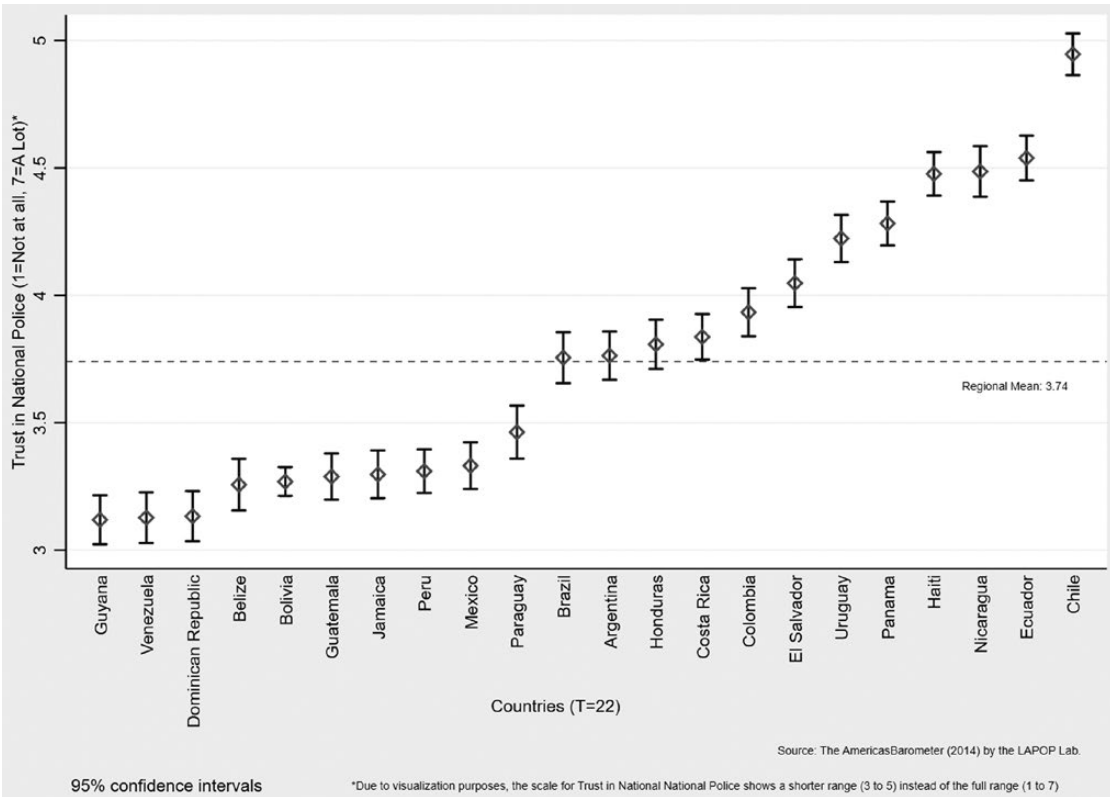

Figure 1: Mean Trust in National Police by Country

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Table 2: Multilevel Regression results for trust in national police (group-mean centred/Null and full models only)

	Null	Institutional	Experiential	Integrated
Regressors	**Model 1**	**Model 2**	**Model 3**	**Model 4**
Individual-level				
Institutional trust score		0.692*** (0.019)		0.647*** (0.018)
Citizen satisfaction with gov. services score		0.300*** (0.066)		0.204*** (0.055)
Political orientation scale		0.008 (0.017)		
Victim of crime in the last 12 months			−0.321*** (0.061)	−0.144*** (0.035)
Police response time (Burglary)			−0.346*** (0.018)	−0.224*** (0.021)
Police corruption or bribery			−0.616*** (0.040)	−0.338*** (0.080)
Fear of crime			−0.218*** (0.040)	−0.056 (0.035)
Demographics				
Sex, 1 = Female		0.090** (0.042)	0.078 (0.045)	0.086** (0.037)
Age, Years		0.003** (0.001)	0.005*** (0.001)	0.003 (0.002)
Family economic situation = 1, Poor		−0.122*** (0.038)	−0.211*** (0.029)	−0.092*** (0.028)
Schooling, years		−0.003 (0.006)	−0.042*** (0.012)	−0.009 (0.009)
Country-level				
GDP per capita 2014 (log)		−0.334** (0.164)	−0.050 (0.158)	−0.349** (0.159)
Homicide rate per 100,000 population 2014 (Log)			−0.185 (0.155)	
Ranking rule of law 2014		0.013** (0.006)		0.013** (0.006)
Constant	3.678*** (0.099)	6.131*** (1.301)	4.684*** (1.448)	6.285*** (1.272)
Variance component				
Country	0.146	0.125	0.137	0.116
Residual	3.485	2.417	3.113	2.321
AIC	116,415.6	75,563.1	106,037.0	84,752.1
BIC	116,424.0	75,644.2	106,129.2	84,859.0
Log Pseudolikelihood	−58,207	−37,771	−53,007.5	−42363.1
ICC	0.040	0.049	0.042	0.048
Respondents (*N*)	34,798	24,558	32,260	27,349
Countries (*T*)	22	22	22	22

Models were weighted using factors for individual-level (wt1500n) and country-level (computed population ratio) and group-mean centred.

Robust standard errors are in parentheses.

Political Orientation Scale (Level-1) and Homicide Rate per 100 K population (Level-2) regressors were dropped from the final fully integrated model due to a lack of statistical significance in prior analysis.

$^{**}P < 0.01$, $^{***}P < 0.05$.

The contextual variables employed underscored some of these patterns: Average rates of homicide are high (M = 22.591, SD = 19.340), and countries are generally characterized by low to moderate levels of compliance with the rule of law and mixed patterns of economic prosperity (M = 35.642, SD = 22.935, and M = 6541.403, SD = 3985.282, respectively). These statistics confirm the importance of accounting for key markers of heterogeneity in predictors and outcomes at the country level.

Next, we specify an intercept-only ANOVA model followed by the fully specified multilevel models for the two models of police trust already discussed (Table 2). Full results are included in Appendix 1.

The intercept-only intraclass correlation for model 1 is 0.040, which means 4.0% of the total

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variance of trust in the police is explained by differences across countries. Model 2 summarizes results for all predictors in the Institutional Trust model. Results show both trust and satisfaction with government institutions and services are positively related to trust in the police (b = 0.692, SE = 0.019 and b = 0.300, SE = 0.066) respectively. Trust in the police is also higher for females (b = 0.090, SE = 0.042), and among those of more affluent economic status (b = −0.122, SE = 0.038). At the country level, results show the measure of the rule of law is positive and statistically significant with trust in the police (b = 0.013, SE = 0.006). Similarly, we find a significant negative association between ratings of the police and GDP per capita (b = −0.334, SE = 0.164). We also note that this fully specified model (model 2) reduced both the individual and country-level variances relative to the baseline: For example, as noted in Table 2, 4.9 % of the variance of trust in the police now takes place between countries increasing from 4.0% variance in model 1.

We reproduce this model-building routine for the Experiential model. As noted in Table 2, model 3, individuals who have been recent victims of crime have lower rating of police trust compared to non-victims (b = −0.321, SE = 0.061). We detect a similar, but stronger pattern in connection to police corruption (b = −0.616, SE = 0.040). The effectiveness of the police measured as a timely response to a potential burglary is also negatively correlated with trust (b = −0.346, SE = 0.018). Fear of crime follows a similar pattern (b = −0.218, SE = 0.040). These findings show that recent experiences of crime and police contact, as well as other specific perceptions of fear and police effectiveness, are related in similar ways to levels of citizen trust, although the strength of these associations varies across predictors.

Demographic factors also provide meaningful results: women trust the police more than men in this model but this is not statistically significant (b = 0.078, SE = 0.045). Older individuals report more positive police ratings than young people (b = 0.005, SE = 0.001), although education follows the reverse pattern, like in the institutional model (b = −0.042, SE = 0.012). We detect a similar relationship in connection to socio-economic status (b = −0.211, SE = 0.029).

The two regressors specified at the country-level for the experiential model are not related to variation in police ratings (GDP per capita and homicide rate 100,000 population). Overall, in Table 2, the fully specified Experiential model indicates that 4.2% of the variance of trust in the police is explained by the variation across individuals and between countries. The ICC value for model 2 is slightly higher than for model 1.

The institutional and experiential models provide specific responses to questions about factors shaping trust in the police in the region. Specifically, results show that individual-level variables are more closely associated with variation in citizen trust in the sample relative to the country-level predictors included in our models. This is not surprising given that our outcome is an individual-level attitude, and that most multilevel models show that the variance explained by contextual factors is generally small. In addition, as mentioned by Liska (Liska, 1990), the absence of a stronger association between contextual variables and individual-level predictors does not mean that they are not important for model estimation or theory development as contextual predictors signal a set of unique mechanisms of group-level influence and provide necessary controls for groups or clusters of individual responses. The results summarized in Table 2 also show that the institutional trust model provides a better fit to the data relative to the experiential model as signalled by the AIC and ICC indicators. Whereas ICCs are comparable for both models, the institutional model's goodness of fit is smaller than the estimate of the experiential model (Model 2 AIC = 75563.1 versus Model 3 AIC = 106037.0).

An integrated model?

We explore how these findings could be used to guide the potential merging of the two models into a single integrated model. This paper aims for side-by-side integration, setting the institutional and experiential approaches as different, but complementary, domains of explanation for a more comprehensive understanding of trust in the police in LAC. This approach is suitable given that the perspectives under consideration emphasize

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control-based mechanisms but differ in terms of framing and the role of contextual influences.

To implement this strategy, we follow the same analytical path employed above. The baseline unconditional model is the same across all models, the first step for integration involved the combined specification of all individual-level variables (see Appendix 1). Results show that institutional trust and satisfaction with government services remain significantly and positively correlated with the outcome (b = 0.647, SE = 0.018, and b = 0.204, SE = 0.055, respectively).

As expected, most of the regressors related to experiences with crime and contact with the police remained negative and significantly associated with the outcome, and demographic controls did not change significantly relative to the two models under examination.[10]

In Table 2 we summarize model estimates from the fully specified integrated model, which included individual and contextual predictors (model 4).[11] Results confirm most effects of the Institutional and Experiential approaches: For example, in the former case, respondents with higher levels of institutional trust also report higher ratings of trust in the police (b = 0.692, SE = 0.019). In the latter case, criminal victimization is negatively associated with police perceptions (b = −0.321, SE = 0.061). In the integrated model, only individual-level controls for sex and economic status are associated with police trust (b = 0.086, SE = 0.037, and b = −0.092, SE = 0.028, respectively). At the contextual level, we find that rule of law is significant and positively related to trust in law enforcement (b = 0.013, SE = 0.006). In addition, results for economic development and police ratings show that GDP per capita is negatively related to the outcome (b = −0.349, SE = 0.159). Comparing the goodness of fit for the integrated model, the intraclass correlation slightly increases the overall fit of the full specified model within a similar range (model 4 ICC = 0.048) compared to the baseline in model 1 (Model 1 ICC = 0.040).

These findings are consistent with those presented for each of the separate models already studied, which supports the notion that the predictors included in each model tapped independent but complementary control-related factors associated with citizen ratings of the police. However, there were some notable differences in the estimates derived from model 4 (see Table 2). In connection to the regressors linked initially to the experiential model, the crime victimization coefficient decreases by almost a half in the integrated model (b experiential= −0.321 and b integrated = −0.144). The same pattern applies to variables associated with police response time and police bribery (b bribe experiential = −0.616 and b bribe integrated = −0.338; b resp time experiential = −0.346 and b resp. time integrated = −0.224). Moreover, fear of crime is no longer significant in the integrated model. In contrast, the two variables originally linked to the institutional model changed little when considered in tandem with other predictors. This was somewhat surprising as we anticipated that more concrete, narrowly defined experiences with crime and policing would exhibit a more robust pattern of associations with trust relative to more distal references to a broader set of institutional actors and interventions. However, these general frameworks guide the process of interpretation and projection of individual experiences and conversion into levels of trust. It is also possible that the stability in coefficients of institutional trust and satisfaction is associated with their shared attitudinal orientation with the outcome.

Table 2 also shows important differences in the association between trust in the police and the set of country-level regressors used for each model. For rule of law, for instance, both the integrated and institutional models show similar, statistically significant coefficient values (b institutional = 0.013

[10] See Appendix 1 for full results. The political orientation regressor is not included in the integrated model as this construct did not reach significance in the institutional model and did not track the more narrowly defined correlates of the experiential model.

[11] Consistent with the approach described in footnote 10, we drop the homicide rate from the list of level-2 predictors in the integrated model as it did predict variation in police trust using conventional thresholds for statistical significance. Our use of a reduced number of level-2 regressors is also informed by the small sample size of countries (T = 22).

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and b integrated = 0.013). The strength of the rule of law is a driving factor of trust in the police between countries. The economic development measured by GPD per capita is statistically significant at the country-level and was negatively correlated with ratings about the police for institutional and integrated models (b institutional = −0.334 and b integrated = −0.349). In contrast, the homicide rate was not statistically significant in the experiential model presented in Table 2 or in the supplementary version of the integrated model which included all three country-level predictors. This result was surprising given previous findings in the literature relating levels of violence in the region to various measures of police performance (Liebertz, 2020). Our results suggest that in the specific case of citizen trust, homicide may be seen by citizens as too far removed from their daily routines and experiences with violence and crime, or unrelated to the most frequent types of police activities anchoring their expectations.

We observe that the institutional model outperforms the integrated model in terms of overall fit. For instance, as noted in Table 2, the institutional model explains more of the between-country variation in trust levels than the integrated model (ICC institutional = 0.049/ ICC integrated = 0.048). It also seems the institutional model fits the data better, as shown by the different AIC estimates (Integrated AIC = 84752.1, Experiential AIC = 106037.6, and Institutional AIC = 75563.1). But these comparisons do not take into consideration variations in sample size due to patterns of missing data tied to specific variables. In a set of supplementary analyses, for example, we constrained the integrated model to replicate the structure of the sample of the institutional model and find that the integrated model performs better than its institutional counterpart. We also checked the robustness of our findings using a more straightforward specification of all three models discussed based on fixed-effects and OLS estimators. The results of these analyses did not yield substantial differences from the main results presented above with all key predictors of the institutional, experiential, and integrated frameworks remaining associated with variation in trust per the findings already discussed. Furthermore, we also fit random-effects models as an alternative way to model our data. Results from the Hausman test comparing fixed-effects and random-effects show that errors are not significantly correlated with any of the regressors across all models. We also ran our models using a multinomial logit specification meant to reflect more precisely the measurement properties of our dependent variable. The estimates derived from this alternative approach did not differ substantially from those presented here.[12]

Substantively, we consider the integrated model to be more comprehensive in terms of potential correlates of trust in the police across levels and domains of behaviour/framing. As such, this perspective re-centres trust as both an outward-looking perception derived from broader citizen views on state capacity/legitimacy and politics, and as an inward-looking perception anchored on more narrow concerns about police effectiveness. Importantly, the complementarity of these perspectives can be extended from individual-level to country-level predictors as well (Bernard and Snipes, 1996).

In sum, we observe that model integration is far from being a straightforward task: on the one hand, this approach requires an assessment of both variable-specific estimates and global statistics that could lead to potentially conflicting results if not studied in connection to other issues tied to sampling, measurement, and theory. On the other hand, the evaluation of an integrated perspective needs more than just empirical work: in our study, the integrated model makes a substantive contribution in terms of realigning the two theoretical perspectives that surpass the scope of its constitutive parts.

Discussion

This study sought to bring closer together two different and complementary approaches to explain the variation of trust in the police in LAC. In this sense, our findings are aligned with previous research regarding the association of law

[12] Results available upon request from the corresponding author.

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enforcement ratings and perceptions of the quality of democracy and government expectations (Cao *et al.*, 2012; Jang *et al.*, 2015). In particular, the institutional model results show that higher scores in institutional trust and satisfaction were positively correlated with the outcome. However, the institutional model rules out the potential association of political orientation on the outcome which differs from the literature (Cao and Zhao, 2005; Stack and Cao, 1998). A possible explanation regards the explanatory power of the institutional trust dimension including the attitudes related to the political system entities as a proxy for political orientation. These results extend prior work by showing that at the country-level rule of law measures also correlate positively with trust in the police (Bergman, 2002; Davis, 2006; Doyle, 2011). Consistent with another body of literature, estimates derived from the experiential model lent additional credence to the role of individual experiences of victimization, police corruption, and sense of police efficiency and fear of crime in shaping trust ratings (Alda *et al.*, 2017; Blanco, 2013; Kääriäinen, 2007). In sum, institutional and experiential dimensions conform to the variation of trust in the police at the individual level. In that sense, further research can explore the association of tough-on-crime attitudes and police ratings in connection with political alignment and cumulative or vicarious crime-related experiences. Surprisingly, for the experiential model at the country level, however, neither the GDP per capita nor the homicide rate are statistically significant predictors of citizen trust in the police.

This paper adds to the literature by proposing an integrated model that synthesizes the parallel models reviewed above. From a measurement perspective, the institutional model provides a better fit to the data as shown by the AIC statistics relative to the two baseline models examined. In addition, this specification reduces the unexplained variance at the level of individuals and countries.

Theoretically, the integrated model provides a more comprehensive understanding of trust in the police as an individual process of preference formation anchored on both outward-looking (institutional model) assessments as well as more narrow, inward-looking appraisals of guardianship and routine activities (experiential model). Both perspectives emphasize varying forms of control-related arguments that operate at different levels of analysis. The use of side-by-side integration allows us to model these varying effects and expectations. Importantly, this strategy also points to the importance of reconsidering valuations of police legitimacy and effectiveness as potentially framed in separate but interrelated frameworks: the former is more closely linked to broad perceptions of state capacity, inclusion, and rule of law, and the latter, centred on more localized assessments of police responsivity and situational prevention.

Findings from the integrated model show that the GDP-based measure of economic development included in the regressions is negatively correlated with trust in the police. This adds to the literature on potential mechanisms by which growth and apparent prosperity can undermine trust in law enforcement, particularly in developing countries. Following Bergman (Bergman, 2018), the economic expansion of goods and services in Latin American societies of the past decade could have created more opportunities for crime activity due to the surge of different illicit markets leading to more violent and property crimes in LAC. Moreover, it is also possible that periods of economic expansion may have led to the emergence of more visible middle classes with higher, more ambitious expectations of local policing services (procedural justice, faster respond times, etc.). While these demands are visible, and to some extent effective as agenda-setting mechanisms, they may not be representative of other population groups suffering from economic marginalization and alienation. For these groups, the lack of police resources and access to other government services may lead to heightened vulnerability, isolation, and cynicism (González, 2017). Combined, these forces may affect the legitimacy of police institutions as a reflection of a particular form of *collective estrangement* (Bell, 2017). Some authors (Beato and Ribeiro, 2016; Dammert, 2016) argue that changes in deployment strategies and expenditures to increase police personnel over the years are attempts to overcome the public's effectiveness demands but have unclear positive effects on crime reduction.

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In addition, according to the institutional anomie theory, we could argue that rapid periods of economic change may lead to more anomic societies due to changes in social cohesion and social control. Then, in LAC, economic development may operate as a contextual factor to explain the negative association with trust in the police, amplifying at the same time between-country differences. This is mediated by the two elements mentioned above: the increase of violence due to illicit markets taking advantage of the economic prosperity and the perception of a lack of police effectiveness impacting the provision of public safety. More data and analyses are necessary to test the covariation at the country-level, for instance, using panel data or more robust measures of institutional capacity and control mechanisms.

Given the high levels of homicide rates in the region, further analysis is necessary to explore why homicide rates in our study are not related to trust in the police. Whereas prior studies focussed on country-level analyses have shown a positive relationship between these two variables (Cao and Zhao, 2005; Kääriäinen, 2007), it is possible that our assessment incorporates relative risk via individual-level measures of fear or victimization, or that this effect is absorbed by the fixed-effects specified in the models. It is also possible that patterns differ more across sub-regions than across countries, for instance, the homicide level in the northern triangle of Central America versus the other countries in the sub-region, or the southern cone of Latin America. In a similar fashion, citizens in LAC countries may not consider variation in homicide to be representative of police work, especially if they value other domains of performance—like legitimacy—or if they consider homicide to be exogenous to public safety delivery. Finally, it is possible that issues of data quality in homicide statistics may weaken comparative assessments as deaths may be undercounted or categorized using different rules (Bergman, Cafferata and Ambrogi, 2021; Ribeiro *et al.*, 2015). Future studies may consider adding other controls for specific policing strategies focussed on crime/homicide prevention, although issues of operationalization of policies across countries in the region may create new challenges (Frühling, 2009; Malone and Dammert, 2020).

Given the exploratory nature of our analysis and the small number of countries included in our models (T = 22), we are not able to fully explore these propositions empirically, for example, via cross-level interactions. We argue the issues raised may be addressed by other studies comparing estimates from single-country analyses based on a set of uniform predictors, or by other comparative research based on a broader sample of countries from the global south. The use of cross-level data also adds a limitation to exploring how variation in the trust of the police may change over time based on the volatility of local economies, governments, or new crime control policies.

It is important to acknowledge the specific methodological challenges posed by the measurement of trust in the police (Hough, 2012; Jackson *et al.*, 2011; Schaap, 2018). The Americas Barometer Survey operationalized this concept using a single item as a way to simplify data collection/translation across countries in the region. However, as noted by other research, even in multi-item scales set to measure varying modes of appraisal of police work, trust is a core, normative-oriented concept that has been used to bridge micro-macro levels of analysis (Gau, 2010; Jackson *et al.*, 2013). Additionally, challenges in surveying underrepresented groups in public opinion research persist even though more robust and comprehensive sampling designs and recruiting strategies are in place to address potential methodological constraints [Tourangeau, 2014]. Similarly, the literature pointed out that minorities, young individuals, or marginalized communities tend to be more exposed to negative experiences with law enforcement shaping the variation compared to other groups in the population (Boateng, 2016; González, 2020; Hough, 2012). We argue that these two elements constitute a potential limitation to expanding the scope of trust research and perceived experiences between the police and members of the public, especially for underrepresented and marginalized groups.

Moving forward, however, it would be critical for regional data collection efforts to expand the battery of survey questions to better unpack ratings of discrete police encounters from more general valuations of responsivity, fairness, legitimacy and other

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associated concepts that mobilize varying notions of trust and citizen security (Blanco, 2013; Dammert, 2014). The Americas Barometer 2014 dataset provides a broader regional picture of the trust in the police considering the number of countries included in the survey wave. Similarly, by drawing on a greater sample of countries in the global south it may be possible to better capture potential country-level effects.

We understand that recent events, like nationwide protests, could affect individuals' police perceptions dynamics adding visibility to police violence or broader scrutiny of state action and policy. However, the literature points out that the perceptions of trust in the police are usually negative at the regional and national levels (Alda *et al.*, 2017; Malone and Dammert, 2020). In Mexico, for instance, 23% declare they do not have trust in the police at all and only 5% have a great deal in police confidence (Baek *et al.*, 2021). Therefore, further research would explore the dynamics of trust in the police using more updated data and panel data modelling to capture the variation of police ratings over time. For all the limitations mentioned above, it is necessary to explore methodological alternatives to produce multi-level data about police perceptions, trust, and other relevant topics highlighted in this paper as a relevant step for moving forward to a better and more comprehensive cross-national analysis.

Despite these limitations, our research makes contributions to the literature. From a theoretical perspective, we show how different substantive frameworks can be contrasted or integrated to develop more robust frameworks. This is particularly important in the modelling of citizen attitudes toward the police as these are often reflective of individual and contextual influences. Our work expands this approach to integration by reformulating trust in law enforcement as sensitive to both inward and outward considerations of government capacity and police effectiveness. Our results also show that while preference formation is largely an individual-level process, contextual factors do play a role beyond simple aggregation: In particular, variables such as GDP per capita and Rule of Law bound these preferences by structuring benchmarks related to resources available for crime control or sense of generalized adherence to democratic mandates.

Findings support policy implications linking structural and individual level dimensions. One element is the combination of institutional characteristics: perceptions about the democracy, role of the state and the government expectations, which was a more reliable driver for trust in the police. Similarly, experiences with crime and the police are associated with individual law enforcement ratings. Governments in the region would pay attention to the overall individuals' attitudes about the police, support democracy and increase institutional confidence by providing a relevant background related to the politics of the police and legitimacy.

As part of a broader democratic environment, during 2019 and 2020, protests were held in some countries in the region, for instance, Chile, Colombia, and Peru (Bonner and Dammert, 2021; Maguire, 2021). However, this situation is not exclusively happening in LAC, we observe the US communities mobilizing to denounce police brutality and misconduct, triggering calls for police reform. Even though are different contexts, there are similitudes regarding the militarization of public safety, excessive use of force, and crowd control tactics that stand in opposition to democratic values, and human rights and may lower trust and legitimacy in the police (Bonner, 2019; González, 2017; Malone and Dammert, 2020; Pion-Berlin and Carreras, 2017). In democratic societies, social protests challenge traditional public order-centred approaches to police the protests. In that sense, these events and their implications can reshape perceptions of trust in the police, making it relevant to consider them to inform police reform.

Supplementary Material

Supplementary material is available at *Policing* online.

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